

Kyrgyzstan



A small and mountainous landlocked state in central Asia, Kyrgyzstan is one of the least urbanized ex-Soviet republics, and was slow to develop its own sense of cultural identity.



GEOGRAPHY

The mountainous spurs of the Tien Shan range contain glaciers, alpine meadows, forests, and narrow valleys. Semidesert in the west.



CLIMATE

Varies from permanent snow and cold deserts at high altitudes, to hot deserts in low regions.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Ethnic Kyrgyz have only been in the majority since the late 1980s – due to a high birth rate and the emigration of ethnic Russians. Wary of losing skills vital to the economy, the government has attempted to deter Russians from leaving; concessions include making Russian an official language. There are some tensions between Kyrgyz and Uzbeks, and a trend toward greater Islamization, particularly in the poorer south.



THE ECONOMY

Mainly still under state control; corruption issues. Agriculture employs half of the labor force. Cotton, wool, meat, and tobacco exports. Mercury, gold, and antimony are mined. Great potential for hydroelectric power.



INSIGHT: Kyrgyz folklore is based around the 1000-year-old poem, *Manas*, which takes a week to recite



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kyrgyz Republic

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Bishkek

POPULATION: 5.48 million

TOTAL AREA: 76,641 sq. miles
(198,500 sq. km)

DENSITY: 72 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Kyrgyz*, Russian*, other

RELIGIONS: Muslim (mainly Sunni) 70%,
Orthodox Christian 30%

ETHNIC MIX: Kyrgyz 65%, Uzbek 14%,
Russian 13%, other 6%, Dungan 1%,
Ukrainian 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Som = 100 tyiyn